Helping students understand and use feedback

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D12 S1–S6

Contents

Helping students understand and use feedback 1

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1. Make comments specific and actionable 1
2. Connect feedback to criteria and examples 1
3. Help students identify priorities 2
4. Check how students interpret the feedback 2
5 Provide an opportunity to use feedback 3
6. Ask students to explain how they used feedback 3
Supporting Resources 3
Feedback response template 4

Students may need help interpreting feedback, deciding what matters most, and using comments to improve their work. Make the next action clear, check students' interpretation, and plan an opportunity to apply the feedback. Use the same subject standards and published assessment criteria for all students.

1. Make comments specific and actionable

Point to the relevant part of the work, explain the issue and identify an action. Replace isolated comments such as "unclear" or "needs analysis" with guidance that shows what the student should reconsider. Identify strengths worth retaining too.

Example - Business
Instead of "Needs more analysis", write: "You have identified three risks. Explain how each could affect the expansion decision, using the case data."

Keep sentences direct. Explain unfamiliar assessment terms or feedback codes when you introduce them. Give guidance without writing the student's answer for them.

2. Connect feedback to criteria and examples

Name the criterion addressed by the comment. Use a short teacher-created or authorised anonymised extract to show the feature in question. Ask students to identify how the extract meets the criterion, then explain your judgement.

Example - Engineering

For "justification of design decisions", show how a different design example connects a choice to test results. Ask: "Where is the decision stated? Which result supports it? How is that connection explained?"

Ask students to locate the equivalent feature in their own work. Use examples that illustrate the reasoning while leaving students responsible for their own decisions.

3. Help students identify priorities

Select a manageable number of improvements. Distinguish changes to subject reasoning or evidence from smaller refinements. Explain the order in which students should work, based on the task and criteria.

Example – Public Health

"First, check whether your conclusion matches the evidence. Next, organise the supporting points. Then address the wording marked in the final paragraph."

Avoid asking students to polish sentences that need to be substantially rewritten. Where terminology changes the subject meaning, make that a priority.

4. Check how students interpret the feedback

Ask students to put one important comment into their own words and identify the action they intend to take. A brief written response, pair discussion or short conversation can reveal misinterpretation.

Example - Economics

"What does my comment about the missing mechanism mean? Show where you will explain how the interest-rate change affects borrowing."

If a student proposes only adding more words, check whether they have understood the required change in reasoning. Provide a way to ask about comments privately. Check the intended action rather than relying on "Do you understand?"

5 Provide an opportunity to use feedback

Plan a revision, a second attempt or a later task that uses the same skill. Return feedback early enough for students to act on it, and identify which comments are relevant to the next task.

Example - Environmental science
Students revise an explanation so it connects cause, mechanism and outcome. In the next task, ask them to check those same connections when explaining a different process.

Where resubmission is not available, use a short practice extract or a future assignment. Clarify whether the activity is practice or contributes to assessment, following course arrangements.

6. Ask students to explain how they used feedback

Ask for a short record of one or two important feedback points, what changed and where. Students can explain a reasoned alternative response where appropriate. Check whether the revision addresses the issue, rather than simply whether a change was made.

Example - Nursing
"The care priority lacked justification. I added a reason linked to the patient information in paragraph two."

A short routine to try
Return feedback with two clear priorities. Give students time to interpret one comment and plan an action. Clarify misunderstandings, allow revision and ask for a brief account of what changed.

Supporting Resources

Emery, D. (n.d.). Creating revision plans and revision memos: Moving from feedback, to planning, to action. University of Minnesota, Writing Across the Curriculum.

King's College London. (n.d.). How can I help students engage with feedback?

University of Bath. (n.d.). Actionable feedback.

University of Glasgow. (n.d.). Respond to feedback.

University of Michigan, Sweetland Center for Writing. (n.d.). Giving feedback on student writing.

Feedback response template

Use this after students receive feedback. Complete the first two columns before revision and the final column afterwards. A few brief notes are sufficient.

Feedback point and my interpretation	Action I will take	Change made and location
Example: My recommendation needs a clearer link to the case evidence.	Compare the options using the case data and explain why the evidence supports my choice.	Added a comparison and justification in paragraphs 3 and 4.

Question I need clarified: _____

If I chose a different response, my reason: _____